

Innovative User Interfaces

Device makers are focusing on making user-interfaces easy, clean and intuitive. As more and more technology surrounds our life, it should blend with the environment, be less blatant and mingle naturally with users

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It is easier to interact with humans than with machines. The reason is simple: Even if the person at the other end speaks a different language, we will exercise our intelligence to understand what he is trying to say, just as he tries to put his point forth using his body language. So the communication effort

is two-way. However, with machines you have to communicate in a precise manner that they will understand. You cannot say just anything to them and leave their software to do the interpretation. One wrong command can send things helter-skelter.

Hope is in sight. A lot of human-machine interaction experts around the world are working on simplifying our interactions with machines. They are coming up with innovative user-interfaces that are easier, more natural, intuitive and human.

It is becoming possible to give instructions verbally to computers and mobile phones, express your instructions as simple gestures, or even make your machines understand what you are thinking. Speech, gestures and thought are promising to be the future of human-machine interfacing.

While the medium of interface is one key trigger for innovation in the area of user-interfaces, there are other interesting motives as well. These include making user-interfaces that consume and dissipate less energy, are smaller, lighter and less harmful to the environment, use

more natural materials, and meet the special needs of challenged users or specific applications. Designers are also trying to make user interfaces that are less conspicuous and blend with the environment. Otherwise, a future scenario filled with computers (the vision of ubiquitous computing) would look like a computer science lab!

"Good user interfaces are crucial for good user experience. A technology, no matter how good, will hardly reach a breakthrough if designers don't manage to make the user-interface as intuitive and attractive as possible. To be interested in a new product or technology, users need to understand its advantages or find themselves impressed or involved," says Rajeev Karwal, CEO and founder, Milagrow Business & Knowledge Solutions.

"At Milagrow, we are constantly studying the consumers in their own environment. Our product and R&D team has to spend at least two days every month with the consumers using our current or future products. We are focusing on interface with robotic products, convergence electronics and mobile products," Karwal adds.

There is rising awareness about the importance of user-interfaces and many related innovations such as SixthSense, LG Magic Wand remote control, Microsoft Surface, Prezi, Air Glove, Samsung's Smart TV range and Tan Le's EPOC headset. In fact, user experience and new user interfaces were the underlying theme of Consumer Electronics Show 2012. Shawn DuBravac, research director of CES, predicted on the eve of the event that 2012 would be the 'year of the interface.' This fits in with his other predictions about technology moving



SixthSense technology demo by Pranav Mistry